VOL 3: THE PASTRY HUT

THE FOULANE FAMILY



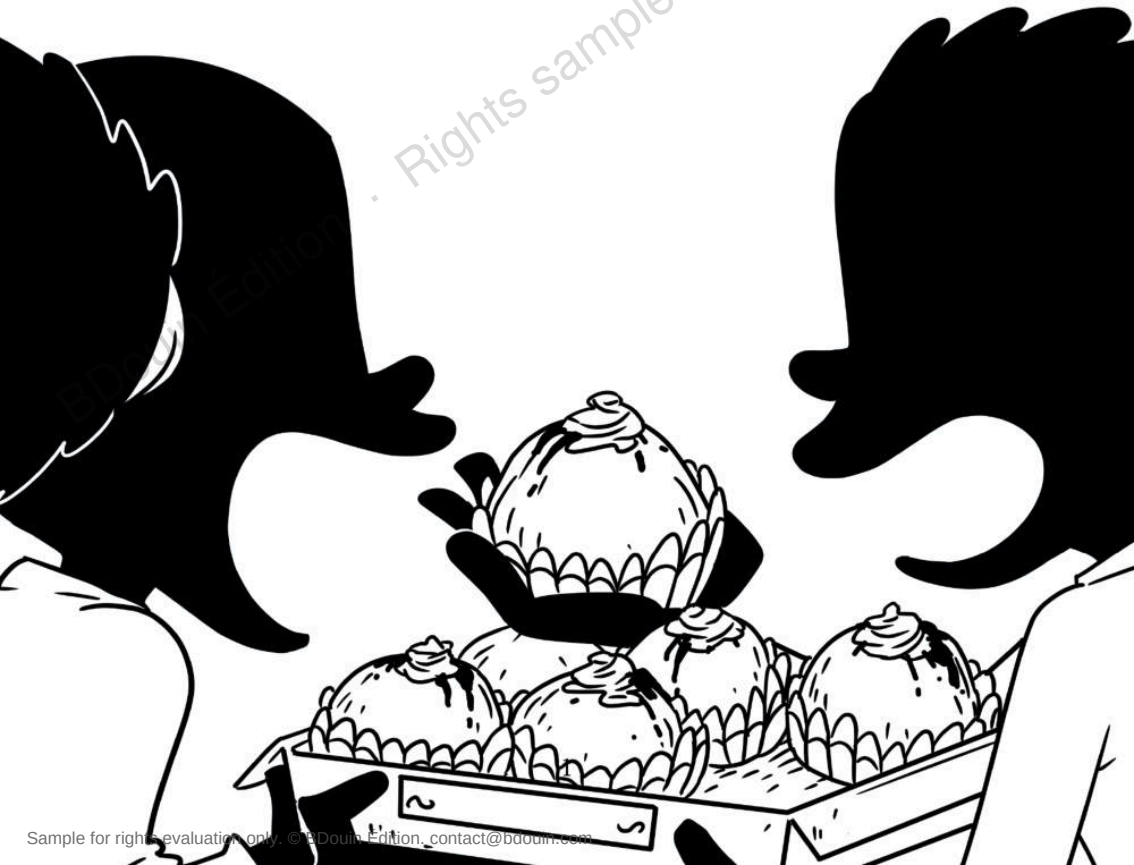
NOREDINE ALLAM

THE FOULANE FAMILY

Vol 3. The pastry cabin

Written and illustrated by
Norédine Allam
Editorial director
Karim Allam

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The Foulane Family

Vol.3

The pastry cabin

By Norédine Allam.

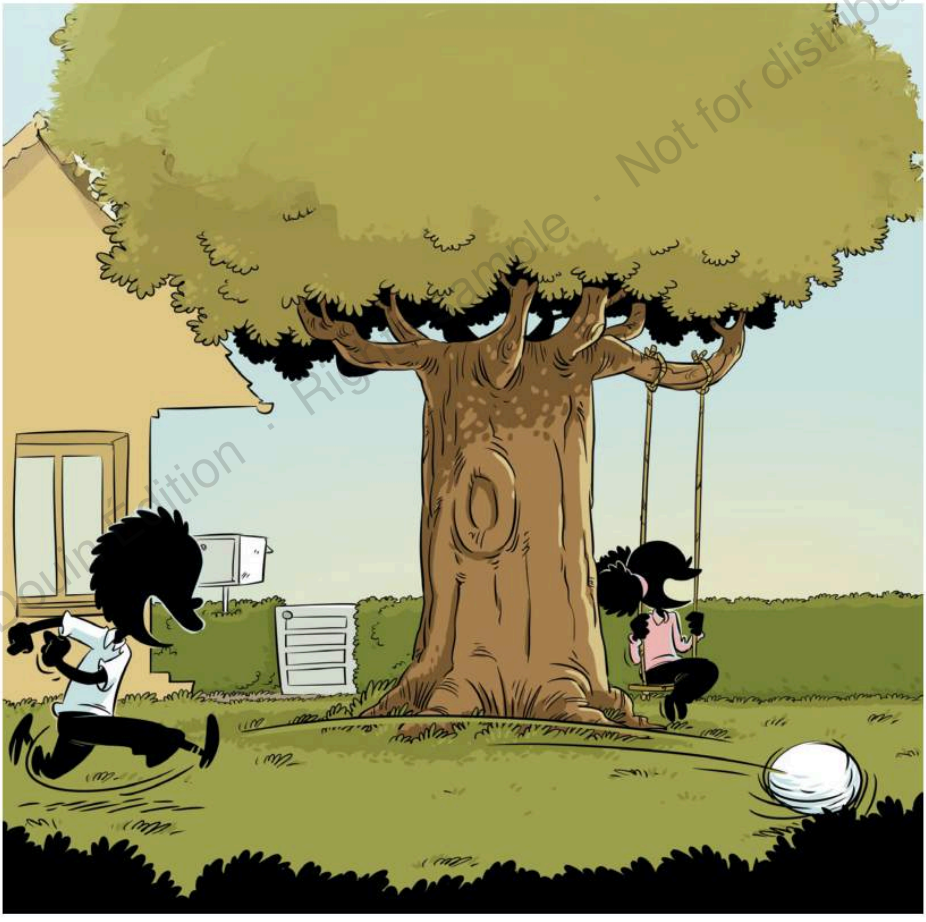
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Ever since the new promotional catalogue from Gardenorama arrived at home, Abi had been determined to take care of the garden seriously.

In my opinion, our garden was perfect as was. It was big enough to run around, had giant hedges on all sides it to keep my football from going into the street, and a humongous tree in the middle with huge branches to hang swings and all manner of things on.



In short, it was the ideal garden.

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But Abi thought differently...



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1. The Ride-On Lawnmower

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It was a Saturday morning when the Gardenorama delivery van dropped off Abi's order... and what an order it was!

Abi had spotted a great promotion for a ride-on lawnmower on the first pages of the catalogue.

I can tell you that when Oummi saw it, she didn't look happy, and Oummi usually loves a bargain.



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"But what are we going to do with this tractor?" she exclaimed.

"First of all, it's not a tractor," Abi calmly explained, "but a SELF-PROPELLED LAWNMOWER. It will allow me to mow the lawn more easily, without hurting my back. And you don't want me to hurt my back, do you?"

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"Of course not," Oummi replied, "but weren't there models that were a bit smaller?"

"Of course there were... and there were also models that were much bigger," Abi added with a sly smile. "And as usual, I chose the happy medium."

Abi often has back pain when he tinkers around – that's why he wears a back belt. It's like a boxer's belt, except it's very elastic... and it's not for boxing or bungee jumping, for that matter.



Anyway, I thought the lawnmower was really cool!

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Abi wanted to test it out right away. He was as eager as we were to see what it could do. Indeed, the lawnmower was really loud. Abi yelled that it was normal because it had a big engine under the bonnet.

It was funny to see him driving around the garden at full speed with his sunglasses on his nose. Me and Binti had fun running behind him!



In just ten minutes, the entire lawn had been mown. Previously, with the old machine, it would take him at least two hours to mow the lawn, not to mention the additional two hours of massage needed to treat his back.

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"What a pleasure to garden with such good equipment!" exclaimed Abi as he got off the machine.

"Abi, Abi!" shouted Binti. "Can me and Walad get on it?"

"Hmmm... all right, but please be careful," said Abi. "Don't touch anything. I haven't found the cut-off switch that blocks the ignition yet. I'll go and get the manual and be right back."

One, two, three! I jumped onto the lawnmower's seat and started to turn the steering wheel back and forth.

Binti was not happy at all because she hadn't managed to jump into the driver's seat before me.



"Too late! You can sit next to me as my co-pilot!"

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“Pff! That’s not fair!” she protested.

While I pretended I was driving a racing tractor, Binti started pressing on all of the buttons.



“Walad? What is this big red button for, do you think?” she asked me.

“It’s the start button.”

“Nonsense!” she retorted. “The start button is green! It’s like traffic lights: you start on green and stop on red.”

“NO WAY! On a tractor, it’s the opposite!” I replied. “We start with red and stop with green, because there’s a big engine under the bonnet.”

“WANNA TRY?!” she challenged me before punching the green button.

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BRRAAOOOUMMMMM!



"WHAT DID YOU DO?!" I shouted.

My ever-adventurous sister had started the engine!

The machine was shaking all over.

"Quick!! Stop everything!" I pleaded.

Binti pressed all the buttons, but to no avail. Green, red, black... none of them did anything!



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“Nothing is working!!” she cried.

In a moment of panic, I pressed all the pedals to try to stop the engine... big mistake. The lawnmover moved off like an F1 car! I was no longer in control: my shoe had got caught between the pedals, and I couldn’t get my foot out!

Abi, who had heard the roar of the engine, rushed out of the house, followed closely by Oummi.



“BRAKE, WALAD!! BRAKE!!”

I couldn’t brake. In fact, it was the tree in the garden that managed to stop us, and very effectively too.

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The lawnmower had collided with the trunk. Binti had leaves all over her hair, and I had a nest on my head that felt like a racecar helmet.



That's when I saw Oummi running past Abi, shouting, "Ah! My children!"

While Abi, on his heels, screamed, "Ah! My lawnmower!"

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Al hamdoulilah. Me and Binti were perfectly fine. Not even a scratch, unlike the lawnmower.



“Abi... I’m sorry,” I whispered.

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“It’s okay.” Abi whispered back to console me. “It’s my fault. I should never have let you sit on it without activating the cut-off switch.”

“Abi, do you think you can fix it?” Binti asked.

The entire front of the machine was demolished. The headlights hung from the bumper. Black liquid was spilling onto the grass, smoke was coming out of the engine. It was really not a pretty sight.



“I don’t think we can fix it,” Abi said sadly.

“Maybe Grandma DIY can?” Oummi suggested.

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